A STRAIGHT-TALK GUIDE

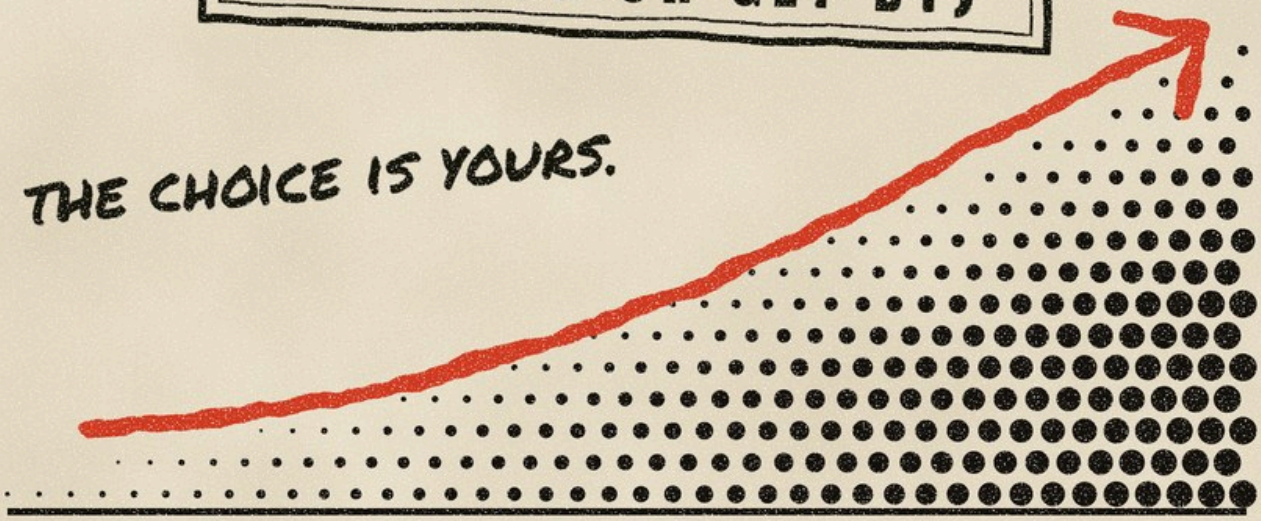
BITCOIN · ETHEREUM · DEFI

# *from* ~~VICES~~

# *to* INVESTMENTS

(GET HIGH OR GET BY)

THE CHOICE IS YOURS.



TURN THE MONEY YOU BURN INTO MONEY YOU BUILD

A STRAIGHT-TALK GUIDE TO MAKING YOUR MONEY WORK

# FROM VICES TO INVESTMENTS

## (Get High Or Get By)

*Turn the money you burn into money you build.*

18 CHAPTERS · 3 PARTS · WORKSHEETS & GLOSSARY

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BEFORE WE START

# Preface

Let me ask you something, and I want you to answer it honestly, just for yourself. How much did you spend last month on things you didn't need?

I don't mean the rent or the light bill. I mean the extras: the smoke, the drinks, the late-night food, the bets, the packages that showed up at your door. Most people can't answer that question without guessing. And the guess is almost always lower than the truth.

That's what this book is about. It isn't a lecture, and I'm not here to judge you. I'm here to help you do the math you've been avoiding, and then show you what that money could become if it had a different job.

This book is written for the person who can afford their habits. The bills get paid. The paycheck keeps coming. The smoke, the drinks, the bets, and the shopping don't hurt in the moment. That's exactly why the money slips away: nothing ever forces you to stop. So the question was never "Can I afford it?" The question is "What else could that money be doing?"

In the pages ahead, we'll look at what your habits really cost, why they stick, and how to loosen their grip without turning your life upside down. Then we'll talk about where that money can go instead: Bitcoin, Ethereum, and the world of decentralized finance, which people call DeFi. It's a new way of handling money, and it's growing fast.

A few things before we start.

You don't have to quit everything. This isn't about being perfect. It's about being intentional, and even a small shift makes a real difference over time.

Nothing in this book is a promise. Crypto moves up and down, sometimes hard, and I'll be straight with you about the risks. I'll show you how to start small, protect yourself, and keep from getting got. This is education, not financial advice, and every choice is yours.

Get high or get by. Pick your lane. Let's get into it.

PART I

# Understanding Vices

CHAPTER 1

# Everybody's Got One

Think about your Friday. The check lands around noon, and by one o'clock you already have a plan. Maybe it's the spot where the bartender knows your order. Maybe it's the stop on the way home, or the drive-thru after a long week, or the cart you've been "just looking at" since Tuesday. Nobody forced you. Nobody even had to ask. The plan formed on its own, the way it always does, and the money moved.

That's a vice. It's anything you keep paying for that takes more from you than it gives back. It could be the smoke, the drinks, the fast food, the scratch-offs, the sports bets, the sneakers you already have three pairs of, or the fourteen subscriptions you forgot to cancel.

And I want to be clear about something: none of this makes you a bad person. Most vices started out as ways to relax, celebrate, or get through a rough day. Somebody handed you a drink at a good time in your life, or a long week made the drive-thru feel earned. That's human. The trouble starts when the thing stops being an occasion and turns into a routine. Anything you repeat with money attached eventually becomes a bill.

## Why it sticks

A vice isn't a mystery. It sticks because it works, at least for a minute. The smoke takes the edge off. The drinks make a long week feel shorter. The food hits at eleven at night when you're tired and don't feel like cooking. The package arriving gives you a small rush, and for a second the day feels better. Your brain remembers that relief. The next time the same feeling shows up, it points you right back to the same fix.

That's the loop: a trigger shows up, you act on the habit, you get the reward, and then you repeat it. The more times you run that loop, the more automatic it gets, until you're not choosing anymore. You're just following the groove.

There's a crowd factor too. A lot of vices live in a social setting: the cookout, the lounge, the group chat, the Sunday game. Sometimes the habit isn't really about the thing itself. It's about who you're with when you do it. That makes it harder to spot, and harder to change.

## The trap of "I can afford it"

Here's what makes this different when you're doing okay. When money is tight, a habit shows itself fast. The cash runs out and you feel it. But when you're stable, nothing pushes back. The rent gets paid. The car note gets paid. The habit gets paid too. There's no alarm and no warning light.

So the habit doesn't feel expensive. It feels normal, like it's part of the budget, part of life. And that's the trap. When nothing hurts, nothing changes. Meanwhile, the money goes out week after week, and a few years later you look up and wonder where it all went.

I'm not telling you to feel bad about it. You earned that money. I'm asking you to look at it the way a business owner would look at an expense: is this getting me something I would choose again?

## What the money isn't doing

Every dollar you spend is a dollar that can't do something else. Economists call that opportunity cost, and it's the quiet part of every vice.

When you spend a hundred dollars on something that's gone by Sunday, you're not only out the hundred. You're out whatever that hundred could have become if you'd put it to work. One time, it doesn't matter. But when it's the same hundred every week for years, that's a lot of building you never did.

That's the whole idea behind this book. You don't have to give up your whole life. You just have to give some of that money a better job.

But first, we need to know the real number. That's next.

CHAPTER 2

# Do the Math

Let's start with the one everybody knows. I'm not talking about the average backyard boogie. I'm talking about the good stuff, the Kush and the Za, the top shelf. Prices change depending on where you live and what you're buying, so just for argument's sake, let's say it's ten dollars a gram.

Someone smoking an eighth a day, 3.5 grams, is spending thirty-five dollars a day. That's $245 a week. It's $1,085 in a 31-day month. And over a year, it comes out to $12,775.

Now say you're smoking seven grams a day. That's a seventy-dollar habit, and it runs you $25,550 a year. If your intake is higher than that, or your prices are, do the math with your own numbers. It only goes in one direction.

And that's before the extras. The lighters, the papers, the bowls, the grinders, the cigars, the new piece you buy after you drop the old one. All of that raises the total, and even a portion of it could have been redirected toward something that builds.

So let's flip it. Say you cut back just three days out of every seven, and on those days you put the money toward a little Bitcoin or Ethereum instead. For the daily eighth smoker at ten dollars a gram, that's $105 a week, or $5,460 a year. You can burn it or you can build with it. The choice is yours.

## The same math, other habits

Weed isn't the only one that adds up. Here's how a few other common habits look over a year. For daily habits, the yearly totals use 365 days. For weekly habits, they use 52 weeks. Swap in your own prices and see where you land.

| HABIT | WHAT I ASSUMED | PER WEEK | PER YEAR |
|---|---|---|---|
| Weed (an eighth a day) | $35 a day | $245 | $12,775 |
| Cigarettes | $10 a day | $70 | $3,650 |
| Fast food | $15 a day | $105 | $5,475 |
| Drinking | $10 a drink, 5 a week | $50 | $2,600 |
| Impulse buys | $50 a week | $50 | $2,600 |
| Sports bets and scratch-offs | $40 a week | $40 | $2,080 |

You don't have to be extreme for this to add up. Even ten dollars a week is $520 a year.

## Where the extra money hides

The sticker price is never the whole price. Most habits have costs hiding around the edges, and those are the ones people forget to count.

Take fast food. A fifteen-dollar meal turns into twenty-five once you add the delivery fee, the service fee, and the tip. Do that four times a week and you're spending $100 a week, or $5,200 a year, on food that showed up in a paper bag. Drinking works the same way. A ten-dollar drink is really twelve with the tip, and that's before the cover charge, the bottle, the ride home, and the brunch the next morning to recover. By the time the night is over, the drinks might be the smallest part of the bill.

Betting is sneakier. The tickets and the parlays are cheap one at a time, which is exactly why nobody tracks them. A five here and a twenty there don't feel like much until you add them up and the total shocks you. Shopping hides it differently, in shipping and returns you never make and the matching outfit you bought for the thing you bought. And then there are the subscriptions: the streaming service you forgot to cancel, the app you never open, the gym you haven't visited since spring. Pull up your bank statement and count them. Most people find at least three.

## The ten-year view

Here's another way to look at it. Pick a number you could redirect each week and let it run.

Put away twenty-five dollars a week, and you've contributed $1,300 in a year and $13,000 in ten. Make it fifty dollars a week, and that's $2,600 a year and $26,000 in ten. At a hundred a week, it's $5,200 a year and $52,000 over ten years. At two-fifty a week, you're looking at $13,000 a year and $130,000 over a decade.

Notice that those are only the dollars you put in. They don't include any growth, and they don't account for any losses either. That part depends on the market, and we'll get to it. But look at that hundred-a-week number again. It's less than what the daily eighth smoker spends in three days. Nobody has to give up everything for this. You just pick a number and stay consistent.

And here's the part people miss: you're going to spend that money one way or the other. The only question is whether, ten years from now, you have something to show for it.

## It costs more than money

Every habit sends a second bill, and it doesn't come in the mail. Heavy drinking is hard on your liver and your sleep. A steady diet of fast food is tied to weight gain, high blood pressure, and heart trouble. Smoking anything is tough on your lungs. Betting and impulse shopping can leave you stressed and chasing the next hit. Those costs show up later, and they're usually bigger than whatever you paid at the register.

## Your turn

Before you go on to the next chapter, take ten minutes. Write down your top three habits. Next to each one, put what you spend in a typical week, including the extras. Multiply by fifty-two.

That's your number. Keep it somewhere you can see it. It's the one we're going to put to work.

CHAPTER 3

# The Smoke

There's a moment in a lot of people's day that has nothing to do with the smoke and everything to do with what comes with it. The sound of the lighter. The first deep breath. The shoulders dropping. For a lot of folks, the weed, the cigarette, or the vape isn't really about the substance. It's the pause. It's the only five minutes of the day that belong to them.

That's worth understanding, because if you only attack the cost, you'll miss why it sticks. You're not just buying a product. You're buying a ritual, a break, and for some people, a way to be around friends.

## The math, one more time

We did the weed numbers in Chapter 2, so let's keep this short. An eighth a day at ten dollars a gram is $12,775 a year. Seven grams a day is $25,550. Cut three days a week from the eighth-a-day habit and you free up $105 a week, which is $5,460 a year. Add the papers, the grinders, the pieces, the lighters, and the next piece when the last one hits the floor, and the real number is higher.

It doesn't matter whether it's legal where you live or not. The math doesn't care. What matters is what you're getting for the money.

Cigarettes and vapes have their own math. A pack a day at ten dollars is $3,650 a year. A vape that runs you a few dollars a day is hundreds or thousands over the same stretch, depending on how much you use and what you buy. And those numbers don't include the doctor's bills that tend to show up later for people who smoke tobacco for years.

## What it does to the rest of your life

Heavy, daily use has a way of shrinking things. Not suddenly. Slowly. The morning gets slower. The motivation to start that project gets a little thinner. The workout gets pushed to tomorrow. Sleep gets weird. Some people find they need more to get the same effect, which means the cost creeps up. Smoking anything is also hard on your lungs, and tobacco in particular is tied to heart disease and cancer.

You don't have to be dramatic about it. Just be honest. Ask yourself: is this making my life bigger or smaller right now?

## The "three days off" method

Quitting cold turkey works for some people, but most people do better with something gentler. Pick three days a week to skip. Choose the days that are easiest. Maybe it's the weeknights when you've got an early morning, or the days you're already busy. Don't announce it to the world. Just do it.

The key is what you do with the freed-up time and money. The moment you'd normally light up is the moment you need a replacement ready. A walk around the block. A workout. A shower. A call to somebody. Cooking something. Playing a game, working on a beat, finishing a project you started and abandoned. The ritual of a pause is real, and you can build a new pause that doesn't cost you anything.

Then, the same day, move the money. The $35 you didn't spend on Tuesday goes into the plan on Tuesday, not at the end of the month when it's been absorbed by something else.

## If you want to quit tobacco

If you smoke cigarettes or vape nicotine and you're ready to stop, don't white-knuckle it alone. There are real tools: nicotine replacement, prescription options, and free coaching. In the United States, you can call 1-800-QUIT-NOW to be connected with a quitline in your state. A doctor can talk you through what's right for you. It's one of the best things you can do for your health and your wallet at the same time.

## A note on being honest with yourself

If you try to cut back and find you can't, or you feel anxious, irritable, or sick when you skip, take that seriously. It doesn't make you weak. It means your body has adapted, and you might want a doctor or counselor on your side. Asking for help is a smart move, and it's the fastest way to get your power back.

Either way, the goal isn't a perfect record. It's more days on your terms than days on autopilot. Every one of those days is money that can go to work.

CHAPTER 4

# The Bottle

Nobody ever decided to spend thousands of dollars a year on drinks. It happened one round at a time. A birthday. A promotion. A bad day. A good day. A Tuesday that felt like a Friday. Somebody says "one more," and somebody always says yes.

Drinking is the most social vice in this book, and that's exactly what makes it expensive. You're rarely paying for the drink alone. You're paying for the night.

## The real price of a night out

In Chapter 2, I used ten dollars a drink, five drinks a week, which comes to $2,600 a year. That's a conservative estimate. Plug in your own prices. In a lot of bars and lounges, a cocktail runs well over ten dollars before the tip, and a bottle at a table is a different animal altogether.

Now count everything around the drinks. The cover charge. The valet or the parking. The ride home, because you're not driving. The food you ordered at midnight. The brunch the next day, because you're hungry and tired and want to feel normal again. Add a slow Saturday where you didn't do the things you meant to do. A night out that started as fifty dollars in drinks can easily turn into a couple hundred in total.

Here's an exercise worth doing. Take the last three times you went out. Add up everything, from the first dollar to the last. Not just the bar tab. Everything. Then divide by the number of hours you were actually enjoying yourself. It's an uncomfortable number, and it's useful.

## What it does beyond the wallet

Alcohol shows up in your body in ways that sneak up on you. It disrupts sleep, even when it feels like it's helping you fall asleep. It adds calories without making you feel full. Heavy drinking over time is hard on the liver and the heart, and it raises the risk of several types of cancer. It also has a way of shaving the edges off your mornings, your focus, and your patience.

None of that is a reason to feel ashamed. It's a reason to look at the pattern with open eyes.

## Keeping the fun, cutting the drain

You can change how you drink and still keep your social life. You just have to be intentional about it.

Decide your number before you leave the house. Say it to yourself or to a friend: "Two drinks tonight." Deciding in advance is easier than deciding at 11 p.m. with everyone cheering. Pay with cash for the night if you can, and leave the cards at home. When the cash is gone, so are the drinks.

Alternate. Order a water or a soda between drinks. You slow down, you spend less, and you feel better the next day. Nobody's watching your glass as closely as you think.

Trade a few nights for something else. Instead of the bar, host people at your place. Cook, play cards, put on music. The same friends show up, and the bill drops to the cost of the groceries. Pick a couple of nights a week that are drink-free and put real plans on them: the gym, a class, a league, a project.

And think about how to handle "just one more" before it's offered. Have a line ready. "I'm good. I've got an early morning." Or just, "I'm good." Usually that's all it takes.

## Where the money goes instead

Think about what a modest change looks like. Say you drop from five drinks a week to three. Even if you only count the drinks at ten dollars each, that's $20 a week, or $1,040 a year. Count the extras, the rides and the late-night food and the tips, and it's higher. Move that money on the day you skip, and it becomes a habit that builds instead of one that drains.

## When it's more than a habit

If you try to cut back and find it really hard, or you drink in the morning, or you hide how much you're having, or you shake or feel sick when you stop, that's more than a spending problem. Please talk to a doctor. Stopping heavy drinking suddenly can be dangerous without medical advice. In the United States, the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357 is free, confidential, and open all day, every day, and can point you to treatment and support in your area.

That's not weakness. That's taking your life seriously. And it's the first step to making sure the money you free up is going to something that lasts.

CHAPTER 5

# The Drive-Thru

It's 7:40 on a Wednesday night. You've been going since six in the morning. The kitchen is a mess, the fridge has half a bag of spinach and a lemon, and your phone is already open to the delivery app before you've even decided to open it.

This is the most forgivable vice in the book. Everybody needs to eat, and everybody gets tired. But a few years ago, a fast-food run cost a few bucks. Now a combo is easily fifteen to twenty dollars, and with delivery, you're looking at twenty-five or more. What used to be a convenience has quietly become one of the biggest leaks in a lot of budgets.

## The convenience tax

Let's use the numbers. At fifteen dollars a meal, once a day, you're spending $105 a week and $5,475 a year. If you're ordering delivery, add the delivery fee, the service fee, and the tip. A fifteen-dollar meal can turn into twenty-five without you noticing. Four of those cost $100 a week, or $5,200 a year, for food that arrived in a paper bag.

And then there are the extras. The drink. The side you didn't plan on. The "let me grab something for the house too." Add a few of those and the real average per order creeps up.

Here's the part that surprises people: it's usually not the one big order that does the damage. It's the pattern. A lunch here, a late-night run there, the coffee and the pastry on the way to work. Three or four small ones a day add up to something no one would agree to if you showed them the total at the start of the month.

## Why it's so hard to stop

Fast food is built to be easy. It's fast, it's cheap-feeling, it's right there, and it's designed to taste good in a way home cooking often can't match at the end of a long day. The apps make it even smoother, with saved cards, saved addresses, and promotions that arrive just when you're hungry.

If you tell yourself you'll just rely on willpower, you're fighting a system built to beat you. So don't fight it with willpower. Fight it with setup.

## Make the good choice the easy one

The fix is to lower the effort of eating at home until it's easier than the app. A few things help.

Cook once, eat three times. Pick a day (most people choose Sunday) and make two or three big batches of something you actually like. Chicken and rice. Chili. A pot of pasta with a good sauce. Put it in containers. On a Wednesday night, when you're wiped out, dinner is already done, and it takes two minutes.

Keep a "twenty-minute shelf." That's a short list of meals you can make in twenty minutes with things you always keep around: eggs, frozen vegetables, rice, canned beans, a few sauces, tortillas. Not fancy, just fast. When you have a plan for a bad night, you won't reach for the phone.

Delete the apps, or at least log out. Every extra tap is a chance to change your mind. Take the saved card off, too. If it takes you thirty seconds to find your wallet, you may decide you don't want it that badly.

And leave room for the occasional treat. If you want your favorite spot on Friday, go. Plan it, enjoy it, and don't feel guilty. The goal isn't to ban it. It's to turn it from a reflex into a choice.

## What it gives back

Let's say you cut from seven fast-food meals a week to three. That's four meals at fifteen dollars, or $60 a week. Subtract maybe ten dollars for the extra groceries, and you're still freeing up about $50 a week, which is $2,600 a year. If you were ordering delivery at twenty-five dollars, the savings are bigger.

And there's a bonus that doesn't show up on a spreadsheet. A lot of people find they feel better within a couple of weeks. More energy, better sleep, less of that heavy feeling after a greasy meal. Over years, eating better is tied to a lower risk of heart disease, high blood pressure, and type 2 diabetes. That's money you'll never have to spend on the other side.

## Where to send it

This is the easiest habit to redirect because the money is so predictable. Set the recurring buy for the same day each week, and when you skip an order, that amount is already spoken for. Think of it as paying yourself the delivery fee.

CHAPTER 6

# The Bet

There's a reason the sportsbook is on your phone, next to the weather and the bank app. Betting used to take effort. You had to find a bookie, or drive to a casino, or stand in line at a store. Now it takes a thumb and about four seconds. The easier something is to do, the more of it people do, and the people who build these apps know it better than anyone.

Scratch-offs and lottery tickets work on the same idea, just with a cheaper price tag at the register. A dollar here, five dollars there, ten on the big one when the jackpot's up. It feels like nothing. It's one of the most dependable ways to turn spare money into no money.

## The house always has the edge

This isn't a lecture about morality. It's about math, and the math is not mysterious. Every bet, from a parlay to a scratch-off to a slot machine, is priced so that the house comes out ahead over time. Sportsbooks build their cut into the odds. Lotteries pay out only a portion of what they take in. Casino games are designed with a built-in edge. Some people win, sometimes. That's what keeps the whole thing going. But across all the people placing all the bets, the house makes its money, and the players, as a group, lose.

Nobody puts the losers on the billboard. You see the guy holding the giant check, not the thousands of people whose tickets went in the trash.

If you think you're the exception, you're in good company, because everybody who bets thinks so. That feeling, the sense that you can read the game better than the rest, is the one thing the business counts on.

## How the hook works

Betting is sticky for a few reasons you should know about.

The first is the near miss. When you lose by a single point, or two of three symbols line up, your brain registers it almost like a win. It feels like you were close, so you try again. The apps are good at showing you how close you were.

The second is the free bet. "Get a $100 bonus when you deposit." It's marketing, and it's designed to get you in the habit. The bonus usually comes with conditions that make it hard to walk away with real money.

The third is chasing. After a loss, the urge to win it back becomes powerful. You bet a little more than usual, because you're down, and now you're down more. Chasing losses is how a small habit turns into a big problem.

And the fourth is the quiet nature of it. Nobody can smell it on you. Nobody sees you do it. There's no hangover. It's easy to lose track of the total because there's nothing physical to remind you.

## Count it

The fix starts the same way it does with every other vice. Count what you spent. Go back through the last three months of your bank and card statements. Look for the sportsbook apps, the deposits, the gas station lottery purchases, the casino trips. Add it all up. If you spend forty dollars a week, that's $2,080 a year. A lot of people spend far more than that, and a lot of people who think they break even are surprised to see how much actually left.

Then do something hard. Subtract your withdrawals and any winnings you collected separately. What's the number? That's the real cost of your hobby.

## Setting guardrails

If you want to keep betting for fun, treat it like the entertainment it is, and put a fence around it.

Set a monthly limit, and keep it low enough that you wouldn't care if you lost it all. Keep it separate from your bills, your savings, and your investing plan. Don't deposit more when you run out. Remove saved cards from the apps so every deposit takes effort. Use the limit tools the apps give you, and take advantage of the "cool-off" option if you feel the pull getting stronger. Many places also offer self-exclusion programs that let you block yourself from sportsbooks and casinos for a period.

And never, ever bet money you borrowed.

## When it's not fun anymore

If you're lying about how much you bet, borrowing money to cover it, betting more to chase losses, feeling anxious when you can't bet, or losing sleep over it, that's a sign it's become more than a hobby. Gambling problems are real, common, and treatable, and they're not a sign of weakness. In the United States, the National Problem Gambling Helpline at 1-800-MY-RESET (1-800-697-3738) is free and confidential, and you can call, text, or chat any time, day or night. The older number, 1-800-522-4700, still works too.

## The flip side

Here's the interesting part. The thrill people chase from betting, the anticipation, the hope, the "what if it hits," doesn't have to disappear. It can show up in a healthier form. Watching a balance grow over months and years, because you put in the same money every week, is a slower kind of excitement. It's less flashy. It's also a lot more likely to be yours in the end.

When you move the forty dollars you used to bet into a plan, you're still putting money on the future. The difference is that you're not betting against the house. You're building something of your own.

CHAPTER 7

# The Cart

You open the app to check one thing. Twenty minutes later, there are six items in your cart, including a pair of shoes you've been "thinking about" and a jacket that's "almost sold out." A countdown timer tells you the sale ends in fourteen minutes. You didn't need any of it when you woke up this morning.

Of all the habits in this book, shopping is the one that's easiest to defend. It's not illegal. It's not unhealthy. It looks good, and a lot of people around you are doing it. But the same math applies. It's a repeat expense, and it's quietly costing you the future you could be building.

## Why we buy

A lot of shopping isn't about the thing. It's about the feeling. The little hit of excitement when you add it to the cart. The anticipation while the package ships. The moment you open the box. For a few minutes, life feels like it's moving forward. Then the feeling fades, and you're looking for the next one.

Some of it is also about image. We want to look good, feel good, keep up, fit in, or show that we've made it. That's human. But when your spending is being driven by what other people might think, you're renting a version of yourself that costs more than you can see.

And then there's the way stores and apps work on you. Countdown timers. "Only two left." Free-shipping thresholds that make you add one more item. One-click checkout. Saved payment info. Retargeting ads that follow you around the internet with the exact thing you looked at yesterday. All of it is built to shorten the time between wanting something and buying it, because the longer you wait, the less likely you are to buy.

## The sneaky costs

Impulse buys add up in ways that are easy to ignore. Fifty dollars a week is $2,600 a year. But there's more to it than the price tags.

There are the items you buy and barely use. The shirt with the tags still on. The gadget in the drawer. The gym gear you bought to motivate yourself to go to the gym. There are the returns you never make, because it's a hassle, or the window closed. There's shipping, and the "add this to qualify" items. And there's the clutter, which has its own cost in time, stress, and storage.

Then there are subscriptions, which are the quietest drain of all. A few dollars a month for this app, ten for that service, fifteen for the other thing you signed up for during a free trial. Individually they're nothing. Together, for many people, they're hundreds of dollars a year for things they barely open.

And watch out for "buy now, pay later." Splitting a purchase into four payments makes it feel small. It also makes it easier to buy more, and you end up with overlapping payments across several apps. If you can't afford it all at once, it deserves a second look.

## How to take control

Start with an audit. Pull up your bank and card statements for the last three months and highlight every recurring charge. Cancel what you don't use. Do it today, while the list is in front of you. For a lot of people, this single hour recovers more money than any other step in the book.

Then put in some friction. Delete saved payment info from the shopping sites you use most. Unsubscribe from the promotional emails and turn off the sale notifications. Remove the apps from your phone and use the website, which is a little harder. Every extra step gives your brain a chance to ask a question.

That leads to the best trick in this chapter, which is the 48-hour rule. When you want something that isn't a necessity, put it on a list and wait two days. If you still want it after two days, and you can afford it, buy it. You'll find that a surprising number of things lose their shine by Thursday.

For bigger purchases, try the cost-per-use test. A $200 jacket you'll wear a hundred times costs two dollars a wear. A $200 pair of shoes you wear twice costs a hundred dollars a wear. The question isn't whether it's expensive. It's whether you'll actually use it.

## Keep the joy

This isn't about living like a monk. Some purchases are worth it, because they make your life better or because they give you something to look forward to. The goal is to make those purchases on purpose, instead of letting the algorithm decide for you.

A good rule is to set a monthly "fun and style" budget. Whatever's in it, you can spend without guilt. When it's gone, you wait for next month. That way you're still enjoying your money, but inside a fence you built yourself.

## What it frees up

If you cut impulse spending from fifty dollars a week to twenty-five, that's $1,300 a year. Cancel three subscriptions at around twelve dollars a month each, and that's another $432. Together, that's $1,732, and you didn't have to give up anything you were using.

Send it where it can work. That's a better use of the money than another box that'll be in the closet by spring.

CHAPTER 8

# Taking Your Power Back

If you can afford your habits, nothing outside of you is going to make you change. There's no overdraft notice, no collector's call, no bad week at the register. So this has to be a choice you make on purpose. This chapter is about how to make that choice and how to make it stick, without flipping your whole life upside down.

It starts with the trigger. Every habit has one, and you can't change what you refuse to name. Maybe it's stress after work. Maybe it's boredom on a slow Sunday, or payday, or a certain group of people, or a certain corner you pass on the way home. Pay attention for a week and write down what's happening right before you do the thing. You'll start to see a pattern, and once you see it, you've got something to work with.

Next, give yourself a real goal. "Cut back" is too vague, and vague goals disappear by Wednesday. "Skip three days a week and move a hundred and five dollars every Friday" is a plan. It has a number and a day, and you can tell whether you did it.

Then comes the part most people skip, which is replacing the habit, not just removing it. A habit leaves a hole in your day. If you don't fill that hole with something, the old habit walks right back in. If the smoke was how you wound down, find another way to wind down: a walk, a workout, a hot shower and an early night. If the drive-thru was how you got through the week, learn two or three meals you can make in twenty minutes. If you shopped because you were bored, find something that actually takes up your attention, like a skill, a side project, a class, or a league. If the habit was social, start something new with the same people, like a game night, a run club, or a cookout that doesn't revolve around the thing. And if it was a reward, pick a smaller reward that doesn't repeat every day. A great steak dinner once a month hits different from takeout five times a week.

## Talk back to the excuses

Your mind is going to negotiate with you. Get ready for it, because it's good at it.

The first line is usually "I work hard. I deserve it." And you do. But is this the reward you'd pick if you had a whole menu? Treating yourself is fine. Just make sure it's something you'll still be glad about next month. Then comes "It's my money," and that's true, which is exactly why you get to decide what it does. Nobody is taking it from you. You're just choosing a different job for part of it. After that, it's "It's just a little." A little, every day, for years, is a lot. Go back to the table in Chapter 2 if you need a reminder. And finally, there's the old favorite, "I'll start next month." Next month has its own excuses. Start with one small change this week, even if it's tiny.

## Your circle

Here's something people don't warn you about. The folks around you might not be ready for your changes. Some of them will tease you, or make it awkward, or push you to "just have one." Usually it isn't malice. When you change, it makes them look at their own habits, and that can be uncomfortable.

You don't need to make a speech. You can just say, "I'm cutting back," and leave it there. Find one or two people who will back you up, tell them what you're doing, and ask them to check on you. And if certain places or events are your biggest triggers, it's fine to show up less often for a while. That's not running away. That's being smart.

## How it can look

Before we go further, here's what this looks like in real life. A quick note: the three people you're about to meet are composites. They're made-up examples, built from common situations, not real individuals. All three earn enough to afford their habits, which is the whole point. The numbers are just math, and they don't promise anything about how an investment will perform.

Tre was an eighth-a-day guy. Thirty-five dollars a day, every day, and he never thought twice about it because the bills were handled. One night he added it up on his phone and stared at the screen for a while. He didn't quit cold turkey. He cut back three days a week and filled those evenings at the gym. The $105 a week he wasn't spending, he moved into Bitcoin every Friday before he could talk himself out of it. After a year, he'd put $5,460 to work. What it was worth depended on the market, but the bigger change was the habit itself. He'd started paying himself first.

Nia lived on fast food. She spent around fifteen dollars a meal, nearly every day, which came to about $5,475 a year. She wasn't struggling. She just never had time to cook, or so she thought. She started meal prepping on Sundays, and she cut the takeout down to a few times a week. Her grocery bill went up a little, but she still redirected about fifty dollars a week, which is $2,600 a year. The thing she mentioned most was how much better she felt in her own body.

Mike put about forty dollars a week into sports bets and scratch-offs, around $2,080 a year. He didn't win it back, because most people don't. When he moved that forty dollars into a weekly buy of Bitcoin and Ethereum, he said the difference was simple: the money stayed his instead of going to the house.

None of them were perfect. Each one cut a little, replaced the habit with something else, and moved the money on a schedule. That's the whole play.

## When you slip

You will have a day where you do the old thing. That doesn't mean you failed. It means you're a person.

What matters is the next move. Don't use one slip as a reason to throw out the whole plan. Skip the guilt, look at what set it off, and get back on schedule the very next day. Over a year, the people who stick with it aren't the ones who never slip. They're the ones who keep coming back.

A word of care: if a habit feels bigger than you can handle on your own, like it's hurting your health, your job, or the people you love, reach out for help. Talking to a doctor or a counselor isn't weakness. It's smart.

You've done the math, and you've seen how it works. In the next part of the book, we'll talk about what to do with the money once you've freed it up.

PART II

# Where the Money Goes

CHAPTER 9

# Investing Without the Jargon

At some point in your life, somebody at a cookout leaned over and said, "You should be investing." They probably said it like it was obvious, and then they never explained how. So let's fix that.

Investing means putting money into something today because you expect it to be worth more later. That's all it is. You buy a piece of something, you hold it, and over time, the hope is that it grows. When you buy a share of a company, you own a tiny slice of that business. When you buy a rental property, you own a place that people pay to live in. When you buy Bitcoin, you own a piece of a brand-new kind of money. Different things, same idea: money put to work instead of money left to sit.

The key word here is "hope." Nothing in investing is guaranteed. Every investment sits somewhere on a line between safe and risky, and the rule of that line never changes. The more something can grow, the more it can also fall. A savings account barely moves, and it also barely drops. A stock can double or get cut in half. Crypto has done both of those, more than once. Anyone who tells you there's big upside with no downside is selling something.

## The usual suspects

Before we get to crypto, you should know the traditional options, because they're the foundation most people build on.

Stocks are shares of ownership in a company. Bonds are loans you make to a company or a government, which pay you back with interest. Mutual funds and exchange-traded funds (ETFs) bundle lots of stocks or bonds together, so you own a little of everything instead of a lot of one thing. That's called diversification, and it's the oldest advice in the book: don't put all your eggs in one basket. Real estate is owning property, either directly or through real estate investment trusts (REITs). It can pay you rent and it can rise in value, but it takes more money to get started and it's harder to sell quickly.

None of these are bad. A lot of people have built real wealth with them. This book isn't here to talk you out of any of it. It's here to show you where a newer option fits.

## Where crypto fits

Cryptocurrency and the decentralized finance built on top of it sit at the high-risk, high-possibility end of the line. It moves faster, in both directions, than almost anything in a traditional account. Bitcoin has dropped by half or more several times in its history, and each time people were sure it was over. It has also climbed to levels that surprised even its believers. That's what you're signing up for: a bumpy ride with a real possibility of a big payoff, and a real possibility of a loss.

Because of that, crypto is best treated as one slice of the picture, not the whole thing. How big a slice depends on you, your goals, and how well you sleep when the price drops.

## Ground rules before you put in a dollar

There are a few things worth getting in order first, and none of them are glamorous.

First, have a cushion. Set aside some money for emergencies in a regular savings account, something you can reach without selling anything at a bad time. A car repair or a missed paycheck shouldn't force you to sell your investments.

Second, don't invest money you'll need soon. If rent is due in a month, that money isn't for crypto. Invest only what you can leave alone for years. Time is the one thing that makes a volatile asset easier to live with.

Third, don't borrow to invest. Using credit cards or loans to buy something that can drop in half is how people get hurt. This book is about redirecting money you're already spending, not creating new debt.

And fourth, keep going to your job. A habit-redirect plan only works if the paycheck keeps coming, and your paycheck is your biggest asset.

If those four things are in place, you're ready for the next step. Before we get to what crypto actually is, let's talk about the part that trips up most people, which is what happens inside their own head.

CHAPTER 10

# Your Money Mind

Here's something that might surprise you. Most people don't lose money in crypto because the technology failed. They lose it because of what they did when the price moved.

They bought at the top because everybody was excited. They sold at the bottom because they were scared. They put in more than they could afford because a friend was getting rich. They held a losing bet for years because admitting it was a mistake felt worse than waiting. It's not a knowledge problem. It's a human problem, and every one of us has the same wiring.

So before we get into the tools, let's spend a chapter on the one you can't buy: your own head.

## Fear of missing out

FOMO is the most expensive feeling in investing. You see a chart going up, or a post from someone showing their gains, or a friend who's suddenly talking about a coin you've never heard of. Your stomach tightens. You feel like the train is leaving, and you're standing on the platform.

That feeling is real, and it's also a terrible advisor. Prices that are shooting up have usually already moved. By the time something is all over your feed, a lot of the early money has already been made. The people shouting about it aren't doing you a favor. Some of them are looking for someone to buy what they're holding.

The antidote is a schedule. If you've already decided to buy a set amount every Friday, you don't need to make a decision when the excitement hits. You've already made it. The plan does the work, and you get to skip the drama.

## Losses hurt more than gains feel good

Researchers who study how people make decisions have found something consistent: losing hurts about twice as much as winning feels good. Lose a hundred dollars and it stings. Gain a hundred dollars and it's nice. That lopsidedness makes people do strange things. They sell good investments early to lock in a small gain, and they hold bad ones too long to avoid admitting a loss.

In crypto, where prices swing hard, that feeling gets turned up. A drop of thirty percent can feel like an emergency. It might simply be a normal Tuesday in a volatile market. Knowing that your gut is going to overreact is half the battle. When you feel the panic, that's your cue to look at your written rules, not your phone.

## The herd

Humans are social animals, and we take cues from the people around us. If everyone you know is buying, it feels safe. If everyone is selling, it feels like the sky is falling. But the crowd is usually most confident at the top and most scared at the bottom, which is the opposite of what you'd want.

That doesn't mean you should do the opposite of everyone. It means you shouldn't outsource your decisions to the mood of the room. Make your plan when you're calm, and follow it when you're not.

## Recency and overconfidence

Recency is the habit of assuming that whatever happened lately will keep happening. After a run-up, it feels like prices will only go up. After a crash, it feels like they'll never recover. Neither is a safe assumption. Markets don't care what happened last month.

Overconfidence is its cousin. A few good calls can convince you that you've got the touch. It's one of the surest ways to take bigger risks than you planned, and it's usually followed by a humbling lesson. The people who last tend to stay a little suspicious of their own brilliance.

## Sunk costs

Then there's the trap of "I've already put so much in." You bought something, it dropped, and now you feel like you have to hold on, or buy more, to justify the first decision. But the money you've already lost is gone either way. The only question that matters is what makes sense from here.

This is one reason to keep your plan simple. When you're buying a steady amount of something you understand on a regular schedule, there's less room for emotional bookkeeping.

## Tools for a steadier mind

A few simple habits help more than any chart.

Write your rules down before you buy, and read them when you're tempted to break them. Use the 24-hour rule: if you feel an urge to make a big move, wait a day before you act. Limit how often you check prices, and if you find yourself refreshing the app, take it off your home screen for a while. Keep the amount at a level where a big drop wouldn't keep you up at night. And talk to someone steady, a friend or family member who isn't caught up in the hype and will ask you what your plan says.

Ask yourself one question when you're about to do something with your money: "Would I make this choice if nobody else was watching and nothing was moving?" If the answer's no, you've probably got your answer.

Now let's talk about what you're actually buying.

CHAPTER 11

# Crypto, Explained Like You're Sitting Across From Me

Let's start with the question everybody's too embarrassed to ask: what is it, really?

Cryptocurrency is digital money that lives on a computer network instead of inside a bank. Nobody owns that network. Thousands of computers around the world keep the same shared record, called a blockchain, of who owns what. When you send someone crypto, the network checks the record, confirms you actually have it, and updates the books. No bank in the middle. No office hours. No "your transfer will post in three to five business days." It's just math and code, running all day, every day, including weekends and holidays.

## Bitcoin

Bitcoin came first, and it's still the biggest. It was designed with a hard limit of 21 million coins that will ever exist. Nobody can print more, not a government, not a bank, not the person who invented it. That's a big part of why people compare it to digital gold. Dollars can be created whenever someone decides to create them. Bitcoin can't. If you believe that scarcity matters, that's the core of the argument for it.

That doesn't mean the price only goes up. It doesn't. The price swings wildly, sometimes by a lot in a single week. What's fixed is the supply, not the value.

## Ethereum

Ethereum came later, and it does something Bitcoin wasn't built to do. It lets people run small programs, called smart contracts, right on the network. Think of a smart contract as a vending machine. You put in the right thing, and the machine does what it was set up to do, automatically, without a cashier. That one idea is what made decentralized finance possible, which is what we'll cover in the next chapter.

## Stablecoins and the thousands of others

You'll also hear about stablecoins. Many stablecoins are designed to stay worth one U.S. dollar. They're handy for moving money around, and they're a big part of DeFi. They're not risk-free, though, and I'll tell you why in the next chapter.

And then there are thousands of other coins. Some are serious projects. Many are noise. A lot of them exist for one reason: to separate you from your money. For a beginner, my advice is to ignore almost all of them. Learn Bitcoin and Ethereum first. You can always branch out later once you know what you're doing.

## Meme coins: the lottery ticket in disguise

One group of those other coins needs its own warning, because it's the one most likely to catch your eye. Meme coins are tokens built around a joke, a cartoon animal, a slogan, or a famous name. They usually don't do anything. There's no product behind them, no business, no use. Their value comes down to one thing: how many people are paying attention right now.

Anyone can create one in minutes, for almost nothing. That's why there are so many, and why new ones appear every day. Some get a rush of attention and shoot up by huge amounts in hours. You'll hear stories of people turning a few hundred dollars into a fortune. What you don't hear are the stories of everybody who bought in after the rush and rode it back down. When the attention moves on, the price often falls to almost nothing, and most never come back.

There are a few ways people get hurt. The creators and early insiders often hold a big share of the supply, so when the price pops, they sell into the excitement and leave everyone else holding the bag. That's called a pump and dump. Some are rug pulls from the start, built to take your money and vanish. Some are pushed by influencers or celebrities who were paid to hype them, or who got in early and want exit liquidity. Sometimes there are so few buyers that you can't sell at all, even if the screen says you're up. And scammers love to clone the name of a famous token, so you can end up buying a fake.

Underneath all of it is a feeling this book has been warning you about. It's the rush of the bet, the hope that this one is the one, the fear of missing out. If that sounds familiar, it should. A meme coin is closer to a scratch-off or a parlay than it is to an investment. If you cut the sports bets out of your life and started throwing the same money at meme coins, you didn't redirect a habit. You swapped one vice for another and gave it a more modern name.

If you're curious anyway, treat it as entertainment money, not investment money. That means an amount small enough that you'd shrug if it went to zero, kept completely separate from your plan, never funded from your emergency savings, and never borrowed. Don't chase one because it's trending, because someone in a group chat swears by it, or because a stranger sent you a link. By the time you hear about it, the early money has usually already been made.

The plan in this book is the boring one on purpose. Bitcoin and Ethereum, bought on a schedule, held for years. Boring is how you stay in the game.

## Where to buy

The easiest and safest route for most beginners is a well-known, regulated exchange or app based in the United States. Names you'll hear a lot include Coinbase, Kraken, Strike, and Cash App. Strike and Cash App are built around Bitcoin, while Coinbase and Kraken offer many more coins. There are other reputable ones too. Whatever you pick, open the account yourself, on the official website or app, and expect to verify your identity, because the law requires it.

Fees matter. A lot of beginner-friendly buy buttons charge around one to one and a half percent, sometimes more on small purchases. Some platforms charge less if you use their advanced version or set up recurring buys. These numbers change, so before you pick, spend five minutes reading the current fee page. Over years of buying, the difference between one percent and three percent adds up.

There's also a route that skips crypto accounts altogether. Spot Bitcoin ETFs are funds you can buy inside a regular brokerage account, the same way you'd buy a stock. You don't hold the coin yourself, but you get exposure to the price with a familiar setup. It's not the same as owning Bitcoin directly, but it's worth knowing about.

## A word about Bitcoin ATMs

I have to be straight with you about this one. Bitcoin ATMs are easy to find, especially around Chicago, and they're also one of the most expensive and most abused ways to buy. Illinois passed a law in 2025 capping the fees at 18 percent. Think about that for a second. Eighteen percent is the cap, and it's still more than ten times what most apps charge. The law also limits new customers to $2,500 a day. Those rules exist because kiosks have become a favorite tool for scammers.

So here's the rule: if anyone ever tells you to go feed cash into a Bitcoin ATM, whether it's someone claiming to be from the IRS, your bank, a utility company, or a "jury duty" office, you're being scammed. Real agencies don't take payment in crypto. Hang up.

## The slow-and-steady method

The most common beginner strategy is simple, and it's the one this book is built around. It's called dollar-cost averaging. Instead of trying to guess the perfect moment to buy, you buy the same dollar amount on a regular schedule, say every Friday, no matter what the price is doing.

Here's why that works. Imagine a coin whose price over four weeks is $50, then $40, then $50, then $60. If you put in $100 each week, you'd buy 2 coins, then 2.5, then 2, then about 1.67. That's about 8.17 coins for $400, an average of roughly $49 each. When the price dips, your fixed dollars buy more. When it jumps, they buy less. You never have to be right about timing.

It isn't magic, and it doesn't protect you from a long decline. But it takes the guessing out, and it fits the way this book works. You already freed up the money. Now you just move it, on a schedule, before it can disappear.

Next, we'll look at the part of crypto that gets people the most excited, and the most hurt: DeFi.

CHAPTER 12

# DeFi in Plain English

Picture a bank. Now take away the building, the tellers, the loan officer, and the business hours, and replace all of it with software that anyone can use from a phone. That's the basic idea of decentralized finance. DeFi, for short.

In regular finance, a middleman sits between you and your money. If you want a loan, you ask the bank. If you want to trade, you go through a broker. If you want interest, you hope the bank passes some along. In DeFi, much of that middleman work is handled by smart contracts, the vending-machine programs we talked about in the last chapter. They sit on a blockchain, and anyone with a wallet can use them. No application, no approval, no waiting on a manager.

That's the pitch, and it's a real one. DeFi is open all day, every day. It's transparent, because the rules are written in code that anyone can read. And you keep control of your own money, as long as you hold it in your own wallet.

## What you can actually do in DeFi

There are three main things that matter for a beginner.

The first is lending and borrowing. Some platforms let you deposit your crypto into a pool, and borrowers pay interest to use that pool. You earn a share of that interest. Others let you borrow against what you already own. You put up some crypto as collateral and take out a loan, which means you can get cash without selling what you hold. Aave is one of the better-known examples. I'm mentioning it so you know what it looks like, not so you'll rush out and use it.

The second is trading on decentralized exchanges. Platforms like Uniswap let you swap one token for another directly from your wallet, without going through a company that holds your money.

The third is earning by providing liquidity or by staking. When you add your tokens to a trading pool, you can earn a cut of the fees people pay to trade. Staking is a bit different. You lock up certain coins to help secure a network, and you earn rewards for it. Both can pay, and both come with risk.

## The part nobody puts in the ad

DeFi is exciting, and it's also where a lot of people lose money. So let me lay out what can go wrong, because knowing it ahead of time is half the protection.

Code can have bugs. A smart contract is only as good as the people who wrote it, and hackers spend all day looking for mistakes. Even well-known platforms have been drained before. If the code fails, there's no customer service line to call, and there's no insurance like there is for a bank account.

Stablecoins can slip. A coin that's supposed to hold at one dollar can lose that peg, and when that happens, the money can evaporate fast. It has happened before, and not just with obscure coins.

Some projects are built to rob you. People launch a token, hype it up, take in everybody's deposits, and disappear. It's called a rug pull, because the rug gets pulled out from under you. The giveaway is usually a yield that sounds too good to be true. If a site is promising you huge returns that never move, with no risk, walk away.

Providing liquidity has its own trap. If the prices of the two tokens you put in drift apart, you can end up with less value than if you'd just held them. People call it impermanent loss, and it catches a lot of beginners off guard.

And there's a plain old human risk. DeFi has no undo button. If you send money to the wrong address, or approve a shady site to access your wallet, nobody can reverse it.

None of that means you should stay away forever. It means you shouldn't walk in blind.

## How to approach it

Here's the path I'd suggest. Start with Chapter 11 and get comfortable buying and holding Bitcoin and Ethereum. Learn how a wallet works. Then, when you're ready, try DeFi with an amount so small that losing it wouldn't ruin your week. Make a tiny test transaction first. Use the platforms that have been around a long time and have been tested by lots of money and lots of attackers. Never put in more than you can afford to lose, and never chase a yield just because it's big.

The yields you see advertised aren't guarantees. They change daily, sometimes by the hour, and they can drop to almost nothing.

Think of DeFi as the advanced class. You don't need it on day one. Plenty of people do well just buying on a schedule and holding. If it interests you, learn it slowly. Treat it with respect, and it can be a powerful tool.

CHAPTER 13

# Starting Without Getting Got

You can do everything right with the math and still lose your money to somebody sharper than you. This chapter is about not letting that happen.

Crypto has a reputation, and some of it is earned. When money moves fast and there's no bank to reverse a mistake, scammers show up in force. The good news is that most of what they do follows a short list of tricks. Learn the tricks and you're ahead of most people.

## The scams to know by heart

The first is the guarantee. Anyone who promises guaranteed returns, daily profits, or "risk-free" doubling is lying. Real investing doesn't work like that. It doesn't matter if it comes from a stranger, a cousin, or a famous face in a video.

The second is the stranger who got friendly. It might start as a wrong-number text, a dating app match, or a message from someone who seems to be doing well. After a few weeks of chatting, they bring up a "great investment platform" they happen to use. You put in a little and see a nice number on the screen. Then you put in more, and when you try to withdraw, there's always a new fee. The platform was fake from the start. This one has taken a lot of people for a lot of money.

The third is the fake support agent. You post a question in a forum or on social media, and within minutes someone private-messages you, offering help. They're not support. Real companies don't slide into your inbox.

The fourth is the giveaway. "Send me 0.1 Bitcoin and I'll send back 0.2." It doesn't work that way, ever.

The fifth is the phishing link. A text or email that looks like it's from your exchange, saying your account is locked or you need to verify something right now. You click, you log in on a lookalike page, and they've got your password. If you get a message like that, don't click it. Go to the official app or type the website address yourself.

And then there's the demand to pay in crypto or through a Bitcoin ATM. As we covered, nobody legitimate asks for that. If someone's rushing you, scaring you, or telling you to keep it secret, that's the sign.

Finally, there's the hyped token. A coin that's suddenly all over your feed, pushed by influencers or a friend of a friend, promising you can get in before everyone else. We covered meme coins in Chapter 11, and the warning applies here too. If the main reason to buy is that other people are buying, you're probably the exit for somebody who got in earlier.

## Locking your stuff down

Security isn't complicated, but it does take a little discipline.

Use a long, unique password for every crypto account, stored in a password manager. Turn on two-factor authentication, and use an authenticator app or a physical security key instead of text messages when you can. Text codes can be hijacked.

If you move to your own wallet, you'll be given a secret recovery phrase, usually twelve or twenty-four words. That phrase is the key to everything. Write it on paper, store it somewhere safe, and never type it into a website, never take a photo of it, and never give it to anyone. Nobody who works for a legitimate wallet or exchange will ever ask for it. Anyone who has those words can empty your wallet, and nothing can be done afterward.

When you start, it's fine to keep a small amount on a reputable exchange. As the amount grows, many people move the bulk of it to a hardware wallet, a small device that keeps your keys offline. The saying in this world is that if you don't hold the keys, you don't really hold the coin. That's worth thinking about once your balance gets big enough to hurt if it vanished.

Also, always send a small test transaction first when moving money to a new address. And double-check the address character by character. A single wrong letter can send your money into the void.

## Don't get shaken out

The other way people lose is by panicking. Crypto can drop 20 percent in a week, and when your balance is bleeding in red, every instinct tells you to sell and make the pain stop. Most of the people who got hurt worst in past crashes sold near the bottom.

The fix is to decide in advance. Before you buy, write down how much you're putting in, how long you plan to hold, and what you'll do if the price falls by half. Then check on it less than you want to. The people who do best are usually the ones who set it up and left it alone.

## Taxes: the thing nobody wants to hear

In the United States, the IRS treats crypto as property. That means selling it for a profit, trading one coin for another, or spending it can all trigger a tax bill. Buying and holding doesn't. Earning rewards, like staking income, is generally counted as income when you receive it.

You're required to report your crypto activity whether or not anyone sends you a form. Exchanges have started sending a new form, called the 1099-DA. The first ones went out in early 2026 for 2025 sales, and they show what you sold for but often not what you paid. Starting with the 2026 tax year, brokers are required to also report your cost basis on assets you bought on or after January 1, 2026 and kept with them. Still, the form won't always be complete, and the responsibility for getting your numbers right is on you.

So keep records from the start. Write down the date, the amount, and the price of every purchase. A simple spreadsheet is enough. When tax time comes, talk to a tax professional who understands digital assets. This is one place where paying for good advice saves money.

You now have the basics. In Part III, we'll put it all together into a plan that's yours.

PART III

# From Vices To Investments

CHAPTER 14

# Build Your Plan

You've got the math. You've got the basics. Now it's time to turn it into something you actually do. A plan on paper beats a good intention in your head every time, so grab a notebook or open the notes app on your phone. This is the hands-on chapter.

## Step one: Pick your number

Go back to the three habits you wrote down in Chapter 2, and the yearly cost you worked out for each one. Now decide how much of that you're willing to redirect. Not all of it. Just a slice you can actually live with.

Here's a good test. Pick an amount where you'd barely notice a difference in your week. If you spend $245 a week on weed and decide to cut three days, you're redirecting $105. If you spend $105 a week on fast food and cut it by half, that's about fifty dollars. Don't be a hero. A number you can keep up for two years beats a huge number you drop in three weeks.

Write it down: the habit, the cut, and the weekly amount.

## Step two: Check the foundation

Go back over the four ground rules from Chapter 9. Do you have a cushion for emergencies? Are you using money you won't need soon? Are you staying out of debt for this? If any answer is no, fix that first. It's fine for your first redirected dollars to go to your emergency savings. The plan will still be here.

## Step three: Choose where it lives

Pick one reputable platform from Chapter 11 and open an account on the official site or app. Take your time with the fee page. Turn on two-factor authentication before you put in a single dollar. If you'd rather start inside a regular brokerage account with a Bitcoin fund, that works too. The best place is the one you'll actually use, set up correctly.

## Step four: Decide what you're buying

For your first year, keep it simple. Many beginners put everything into Bitcoin. Others add some Ethereum alongside it, like three parts Bitcoin to one part Ethereum. There's no perfect split, and I'm not going to pretend there is. The point is to pick a rule and stick with it, instead of chasing whatever's hot this week.

### Step five: Set it and automate it

This is the most important step. Turn on a recurring buy for the day you get paid, or the day after, so the money moves before you have a chance to spend it. Automation takes your willpower out of the equation. If the habit money has to be moved by hand every week, some weeks you'll forget, and some weeks you'll talk yourself out of it.

### Step six: Write your rules down

Before the first buy, write a few sentences. How much goes in each week. How long you plan to hold. What you'll do if the price drops by half, and what you will not do. The four personal rules I'd put on that list are these: I will not borrow to buy. I will not sell in a panic. I will not click links from messages. I will not share my recovery phrase with anyone, ever. Sign it if you want to. It sounds corny, and it works.

### What it looks like all together

Let's go back to Tre. He wrote down: "Skip three days a week, move $105 every Friday, buy Bitcoin through one regular exchange, hold for at least five years." He turned on a recurring buy for Friday, and he put a note on his phone with his four personal rules. That was it. His whole plan fit on an index card.

Yours should too. If it takes more than a page, it's too complicated, and complicated plans don't survive busy weeks.

Next, let's walk through what your first year can look like.

CHAPTER 15

# Your First Twelve Months

A plan feels abstract until you put it on a calendar. So here's what a realistic first year can look like. Think of it as a loose map, not a rulebook. Your pace might be faster or slower, and that's fine.

## Month one: Set the foundation

This is a setup month, and you might not buy much of anything. You're getting your pieces in place.

Do the habit audit from Chapter 2 and write down your top three habits and their yearly costs. Check your cushion and the four ground rules from Chapter 9. If your emergency savings are thin, send your first few weeks of redirected money there instead. Choose a platform, open the account, and finish identity verification, which can take a day or two. Turn on two-factor authentication right away, and store your passwords in a password manager.

Then write your one-page plan: the weekly amount, the day, what you're buying, how long you plan to hold, and your four personal rules. Keep a copy somewhere you'll see it.

## Months two and three: Start small and prove it to yourself

Turn on the recurring buy. If you're nervous, start with half of your target amount for the first month, and then step up to the full amount. The point of these first weeks isn't the balance. It's proving to yourself that you can do this on schedule.

Start the tracking spreadsheet. Every time a buy happens, add a line with the date, the amount, the price, and how much you got. It takes thirty seconds, and you'll thank yourself at tax time.

This is also when the old habits will test you. A rough week at work, a friend's birthday, a payday that feels like it deserves a celebration. Use your replacement plan. When you skip the old thing, move the money the same day.

## Month four: Your first check-in

Sit down for twenty minutes. Look at how much you've put in, not just what the balance says. Look at how many weeks you hit the schedule. Look at how the cutbacks felt. Did it feel sustainable, or did you grit your teeth the whole time? If it was too hard, lower the number. If it was easy, you might have room to raise it.

Also check the price swings. Did a drop make you want to quit? Did a jump make you want to double up? Write down how you felt. It's useful information about your own risk tolerance.

### Months five and six: Raise it a little

If the plan is working, find one more thing to trim. Cancel that extra subscription. Cut one more delivery order. Trim a night out. Add that money to the weekly amount, even if it's only ten dollars. The growth you're building isn't only in the balance. It's in the habit of putting the money first.

Around the six-month mark, take a few minutes to review your security. Is your password manager set up? Is your two-factor authentication still working? Do you have your recovery information stored safely? A small review now beats a big problem later.

### Months seven through nine: Learn something new

By now the plan runs mostly on its own. This is a good time to learn. Read about how wallets work. Watch a few videos from reputable educators. If your balance has grown enough that losing it would really hurt, look into a hardware wallet, and practice with a small amount before you move anything big. Learn to send a small test transaction.

If DeFi has been tugging at your curiosity, this is a good place to explore, with very small amounts and a lot of reading. You're allowed to decide it's not for you.

### Months ten and eleven: Think about taxes

Before the year ends, pull up your records. Check that your spreadsheet matches what your platform shows. If you've sold, traded, or earned any rewards during the year, those could have tax consequences. Look at the tax forms your platform expects to send and understand what they will and won't tell you. If you have questions, book time with a tax professional who works with digital assets. Doing this in November is much easier than doing it in April.

### Month twelve: Look back, then look ahead

Lay out the year. How many weeks did you hit the schedule? How much did you put in altogether? Whatever the balance is, up or down, you did something most people never do. You took money that used to disappear and gave it a job.

Ask yourself what you'd change. Maybe you'd raise the amount, add a second habit to cut, or set a target for next year. Set the new plan, and keep going.

If your first year includes a rough stretch, that's not failure. That's an education. You've seen how it feels when the price drops and you stay with your plan, and that's worth more than any chart.

Now comes the long part: sticking with it for years.

CHAPTER 16

# Stay the Course and Grow

Here's the truth about the first few months: they're boring. You set up the buy, it runs every week, and the balance sits there. Some weeks it's up. Some weeks it's down. A lot of weeks you'll wonder if it's even worth it.

That's normal. Boring is what working looks like in the early going. The people who build something don't do it in a burst of excitement. They do it by showing up on a schedule for a long time.

## Keep score, but not every day

Tracking matters, but obsessing over it hurts you. Checking the price ten times a day will do nothing except put you in a bad mood. A better rhythm is to check in once a month. Open a simple spreadsheet and record how much you put in, what the date was, and what the balance is now. Over time, you'll see how much of your habit money has been turned into something, and that number is the one that really matters.

That spreadsheet will also save you at tax time, because it holds the records you need.

## Raise it when you can

Plans grow the same way habits do: a little at a time. Every time you cut something else, like a subscription you don't use or another night out, send that money into the plan too. When you get a raise or a bonus, decide ahead of time what portion goes to the plan. Even an extra ten or twenty dollars a week makes a difference over years.

Remember the ten-year examples from Chapter 2. A hundred dollars a week is $52,000 in contributions over ten years. Fifty more per week, and that's $78,000. Those are just your deposits, and what they're worth will depend on the market. But the habit of raising your contribution is something you control.

## When the price drops

It will drop. At some point, it'll drop in a way that makes your stomach turn. This is the moment the whole plan was built for.

Go back to the rules you wrote in Chapter 14. If you decided ahead of time that you were holding for five years, then a bad month doesn't change the plan. If you're buying on a schedule, a lower price means the same dollars buy more. That doesn't make it feel good, and it doesn't guarantee a recovery. But it keeps you from making the one move that does the most damage, which is selling out of fear.

If a drop really does scare you, that's useful information. It might mean you put in more than you were comfortable with. It's okay to scale the weekly amount down to a level you can live with. That's better than quitting.

### When it goes up

The other side is just as tricky. When the price climbs and everyone around you is excited, you'll feel the urge to put in far more than you planned. Don't. Stick with the schedule. Euphoria has a way of arriving right before reality does, and a plan protects you from both ends.

At some point, you may decide to sell some of what you have, for a house, a business, or something else that matters. That's a perfectly good use of money you've built. Just remember that selling can trigger taxes, so plan for that and talk to a tax professional before you do.

### Growing your knowledge

As your confidence grows, so should your understanding. Read a little each week. Learn how wallets work. Try a hardware wallet when your balance justifies it. If DeFi interests you, go slowly. Start with an amount so small that a total loss wouldn't change your life, and learn how things work before you put in more.

Watch out for the temptation to jump into every new thing that shows up in your feed. The investors who last tend to be the ones who understand what they own. If you can't explain it to a friend in a minute or two, you probably shouldn't put money in it yet.

### Don't lose yourself

One last thing. This journey was never just about money. If your relationship with the numbers starts to take over your life, step back. Money is a tool. Your health, your people, and your peace of mind matter more than any balance.

The habits you cut down were taking something from you. Don't let a new habit, like staring at the price all day, take its place.

CHAPTER 17

# Questions People Ask

Over the years, certain questions come up again and again. If you've been wondering about any of these, you're in good company. Here are straight answers, as best anyone can give them.

### Is it too late to get in?

Nobody knows, and anyone who says they do is guessing. People have said it was too late at every stage of Bitcoin's history. What you can control is how you buy. A small, steady amount on a schedule means you're not betting on one moment. You buy through the highs and the lows, and your timing matters less.

### What if it all goes to zero?

It's possible, and you should be honest with yourself about that. Crypto is a high-risk asset, and some coins and projects have gone to zero. That's why the plan keeps the amounts small, uses money you can leave alone, and sticks with the biggest and most established coins instead of obscure ones. Never put in an amount that would change your life if it vanished.

### How much should I put in?

That depends on your income, your goals, your other savings, and how you handle risk, and I can't answer it for you. A common starting point is an amount you wouldn't miss if it disappeared. Many people begin with the redirected habit money, which is why this book is built the way it is. A financial professional can help you decide how much of your overall picture belongs in a risky asset.

### Should I just buy an ETF instead?

It's a fair option. Spot Bitcoin ETFs let you get exposure to the price inside a regular brokerage account, with no wallet and no keys to manage. The tradeoff is that you don't hold the coin yourself, so you can't use it on a blockchain or send it to someone. If simplicity matters most to you, it's a reasonable choice. If you want to learn how the technology works, owning it directly teaches you more.

### Do I owe taxes if I never sell?

In general, buying and holding doesn't create a tax bill in the United States. Selling, trading one coin for another, spending it, and earning rewards can. Rules change, so confirm the details with a tax professional or the IRS's own guidance on digital assets.

### Is crypto even legal?

In the United States, owning and trading crypto is legal, and it's regulated in a number of ways, with the rules still developing. States have their own rules too. Illinois, for example, has passed laws covering crypto businesses and Bitcoin ATMs. Stay with registered, reputable platforms, and keep up with the rules where you live.

### What if I lose my phone or forget my password?

If your coins are on a regular exchange, you can usually recover your account through the platform's official process, which is one reason to keep your recovery options up to date. If you hold your own keys and lose your recovery phrase, nobody can help you. That's the tradeoff of self-custody. Write your phrase down, keep it somewhere safe, and consider keeping a second copy in a separate secure place.

### Can I do this in a retirement account?

Some retirement accounts allow certain Bitcoin funds, and some providers offer ways to hold crypto in an IRA. Rules and fees vary a lot, so ask your provider, and consider talking with a financial advisor before you move retirement money into anything volatile.

### What if my family doesn't get it?

You don't have to convince anybody. You can simply do your own plan quietly. If you want to bring someone along, share what you've learned about the risks as well as the upside, and let them decide at their own pace. And think about leaving instructions for a trusted person, so that if something happened to you, they could find your accounts and know what to do. Never put your recovery phrase in a place where it could be found by the wrong person.

### What if I still want to chase the hot coin?

Then treat it as entertainment, with a small amount you could lose without flinching, separate from your plan. We talked about meme coins in Chapter 11. The boring plan will still be here waiting.

### What do I do if I get scammed?

Move quickly. Contact your exchange or bank, change your passwords, and report the fraud to the Federal Trade Commission at reportfraud.ftc.gov and to the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center at ic3.gov. Recovering the money is often hard, which is why prevention matters so much. Don't be embarrassed. Scammers are professionals, and they've fooled smart people.

CHAPTER 18

# Get High Or Get By

The subtitle of this book asks a question, and now you know what it's really asking.

There's a version of your life where the money keeps going out the same way it always has. The smoke, the drinks, the late-night orders, the bets, the packages. You get by. Nothing is wrong, exactly. You pay your bills and you have a good time. And ten years from now you look up, and the money is gone, and you can't point to what it turned into.

There's another version where you take some of that same money, not all of it, and give it a different job. You still have your good times. You just don't spend all your money on them. And ten years from now, you've got something with your name on it, built one Friday at a time.

Neither version requires you to be perfect. Neither one requires you to be rich. The only difference is a decision, made on purpose, and then repeated.

## What we covered

We started by looking honestly at what habits cost. Not to make you feel bad, but because you can't change a number you've never seen. We talked about why habits stick, why they're especially sneaky when you can afford them, and how to loosen their grip by replacing instead of just removing. We went habit by habit, through the smoke, the bottle, the drive-thru, the bet, and the cart. Then we looked at how your own mind can help or hurt you, and at where the money can go: Bitcoin and Ethereum, the basics of DeFi, and the risks that come with all of it. We covered how to buy without getting scammed, how to protect what you own, and what to do about taxes. And finally we turned everything into a simple plan you can write on an index card, with a calendar for your first year and straight answers to the questions people ask most.

## What I'd leave you with

Start small. Start this week. The first dollar you move matters more than the perfect plan you keep meaning to make.

Be honest with yourself. If you're not sure you can handle a drop, put in less. If something sounds too good to be true, it is. If someone is rushing you, stop.

Be patient. The people who come out ahead in this space usually aren't the smartest or the luckiest. They're the ones who kept showing up while everyone else got excited, got scared, or got bored.

And be kind to yourself. You will slip. You'll have a month when the old habits come back, or a week when you forget to buy, or a day when the price makes you want to throw your phone. That's part of it. Get back on the plan and keep moving.

This is education, not financial advice. I can't tell you what's right for your life, and neither can a book. Talk to a qualified professional about your own situation, especially when it comes to taxes and larger sums of money.

But I can tell you this. The money was always going somewhere. Now you get to choose where.

Get high or get by? Or build?

The choice is yours.

APPENDIX

# Resources, Worksheets & Glossary

## Where to learn more and where to report fraud

These are general starting points. Websites change, so if a link no longer works, search for the organization by name.

- **IRS digital assets page** (irs.gov/digital-assets): the official source on how crypto is taxed and what you have to report.
- **Federal Trade Commission** (reportfraud.ftc.gov): report scams, including ones involving crypto and Bitcoin ATMs.
- **FBI Internet Crime Complaint Center** (ic3.gov): report online and crypto-related fraud.
- **Illinois Department of Financial and Professional Regulation** (idfpr.illinois.gov): the state regulator for digital asset businesses and kiosks in Illinois. If you live elsewhere, look up your own state's financial regulator.
- **bitcoin.org** and **ethereum.org**: beginner explainers on how each network works.
- A **tax professional who works with digital assets**: for anything beyond the basics, especially before you sell.

**Free helplines in the United States.** These are for when a habit feels bigger than a habit. Numbers can change, so check the organization's website if one doesn't connect.

- **1-800-QUIT-NOW** (1-800-784-8669): connects you to your state's free quit-tobacco program, with coaching and, in many states, help with nicotine replacement.
- **SAMHSA National Helpline** (1-800-662-4357): free, confidential treatment referral and information for alcohol and drug problems, open every day of the year, in English and Spanish. It gives referrals. It doesn't provide counseling.
- **National Problem Gambling Helpline** (1-800-MY-RESET, or 1-800-697-3738): free, confidential help by call, text, or chat, any time of day. The older number, 1-800-522-4700, also still works.
- **988 Suicide and Crisis Lifeline** (call or text 988): if you or someone you know is in crisis or in danger, call 911 or 988.

## Worksheets

Copy these into a notebook, a notes app, or a spreadsheet. Fill them in by hand if you like.

**Worksheet 1: The habit audit.** Do this first. List your top habits, and write down what each costs in a typical week, including the extras. Multiply each weekly total by 52. Then note what triggers each habit and what you'll do in its place.

| HABIT | WEEKLY COST | EXTRAS (DELIVERY, TIPS, ACCESSORIES) | WEEKLY TOTAL | YEARLY TOTAL (WEEKLY × 52) | TRIGGER | WHAT I'LL DO INSTEAD |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |

**Worksheet 2: My plan on one card.** Finish each sentence. If it doesn't fit on an index card, simplify it.

1. The habit I'm cutting is _____, and I'll skip it _____ days a week.
2. The weekly amount I'll redirect is $_____, every _____ (day).
3. I'm buying _____ on _____ (platform).
4. My emergency cushion is in place: yes / not yet.
5. I plan to hold for at least _____ years.
6. If the price drops by half, I will _____.
7. My four rules: I will not borrow to buy. I will not sell in a panic. I will not click links from messages. I will not share my recovery phrase with anyone.
8. The person I'll tell about my plan is _____.

**Worksheet 3: The buy log.** Keep one line for every purchase. This is what you'll need at tax time.

| DATE | PLATFORM | AMOUNT SPENT ($) | PRICE PER COIN ($) | COINS RECEIVED | FEE ($) | NOTES |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |
| | | | | | | |

**Worksheet 4: The monthly check-in.** Take twenty minutes once a month.

1. How much did I put in this month?
2. How many buys did I make out of the ones I scheduled?
3. Which habit did I skip most easily? Which was hardest?
4. How did I feel when the price moved? Did I want to break a rule?
5. Is there one more small cut I can add to the plan?
6. Is my security still in order: passwords, two-factor authentication, and safe storage for my recovery phrase?
7. What's one thing I'll do differently next month?

**Worksheet 5: Cooling off before a big move.** Before any purchase outside your plan, or any sale, answer these.

1. What am I about to do, and how much is it?
2. Why do I want to do it right now?
3. Is it in my written plan? If not, why am I changing it?
4. Who is pushing me, and what do they gain?
5. Would I still do this if I waited 24 hours?

If you can't answer these with a clear head, wait.

## Glossary

**Bitcoin.** The first and largest cryptocurrency, with a fixed limit of 21 million coins.

**Blockchain.** A shared digital record, kept by thousands of computers, of who owns what. Once something is recorded, it's very hard to change.

**Cost basis.** What you paid for an asset, which is used to figure out your gain or loss when you sell.

**Decentralized exchange (DEX).** A platform where you swap tokens straight from your own wallet, without a company holding your money.

**DeFi (decentralized finance).** Financial services like lending, borrowing, and trading, run by smart contracts on a blockchain instead of by a bank or broker.

**Diversification.** Spreading your money across different things so one bad outcome doesn't wipe you out.

**Dollar-cost averaging (DCA).** Buying the same dollar amount on a regular schedule, no matter what the price is.

**Emergency fund.** Cash set aside in regular savings for surprises, kept separate from your investments.

**Ethereum.** A blockchain that runs smart contracts and is the base for much of DeFi.

**Exchange.** A platform where you can buy, sell, and trade crypto.

**Form 1099-DA.** The IRS form that crypto brokers use to report your sales and exchanges of digital assets.

**Gas fee.** The fee you pay to have a transaction processed on a blockchain such as Ethereum.

**Hardware wallet.** A small physical device that keeps your crypto keys offline.

**Impermanent loss.** The loss you can take when you provide liquidity and the prices of the two tokens move apart.

**KYC (know your customer).** The identity check that regulated exchanges require before you can trade.

**Liquidity.** How easily something can be bought or sold without moving its price. It also refers to the tokens deposited in a trading pool.

**Meme coin.** A token built around a joke or a theme, usually with no real use behind it. Its price depends almost entirely on hype.

**Opportunity cost.** What you give up by spending money one way instead of another.

**Pump and dump.** A scheme where insiders hype a token to push up the price, then sell and leave everyone else holding it.

**Recovery phrase (seed phrase).** The twelve or twenty-four words that unlock a wallet. Anyone who has them can take everything in it.

**Rug pull.** A scam where creators take in people's money for a project and then disappear.

**Self-custody.** Holding your own crypto keys instead of leaving your coins with a company.

**Smart contract.** A program on a blockchain that runs automatically when its conditions are met.

**Stablecoin.** A token designed to track a reference value, often one U.S. dollar. It can still drift from that value.

**Staking.** Locking up certain coins to help secure a network, in exchange for rewards.

**Volatility.** How much and how fast a price moves up and down.

**Wallet.** An app or device that holds the keys to your crypto and lets you send and receive it.

**Yield.** The return you earn on money you've put to work. In DeFi it's quoted as a percentage and changes often, and it's never guaranteed.

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This book is for education only and is not financial, tax, or legal advice. Investments, including Bitcoin, Ethereum, and DeFi, can lose value, and you can lose money. The stories of Tre, Nia, and Mike are composites, not real individuals. Talk to a qualified professional about your own situation.